Put Your Loved One's Own Words at the Center of a Hard Decision

Four prompts to capture what the person has actually said, give every relative the same three questions, name the decision and what it depends on, and leave with a sheet for the family meeting.

Where you are

A care decision has to be made soon for the person you're caring for, and the family does not agree. One relative has strong opinions and a loud voice. Somewhere in the hurry, what the person themselves wants has started to go quiet.

This guide gives you four ChatGPT prompts to organize what you already know and to see what you don't know yet. It is preparation, not an assessment. Use only information you have permission to share, with names removed. The AI organizes and drafts; it does not diagnose, assess safety, or decide. Bring clinical questions to a clinician, and call emergency services for an emergency.

What you'll have at the end

You can say in their words what the person wants, show where the family agrees and where it doesn't, and list the questions that have to be answered before anyone decides.

A one-page meeting sheet with four headings: What They Have Told Us They Want, Where We Agree, Where We Don't, and Questions to Answer Before We Decide.

Before you start

- Anything the person has said about what matters to them, now or in the past, as close to their words as you remember.
- Replies from each involved relative to the three short questions in the second prompt.
- A sentence that names the decision coming up. You can start with just the first.

PROMPT 1

Start with what they have actually said

WHY THIS MATTERS

Under pressure, families begin speaking for the person. 'She'd never want that' and 'He'll be fine with it' are guesses dressed as facts. Their own words, even a few of them, carry more weight than any relative's summary.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

What the person has said about what matters to them, what they're afraid of, and what a good day looks like, from any conversation.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I'm caring for someone who has a care decision coming up. Here is what they have said, at different times, about what matters to them, what they want to keep, and what worries them:

> [PASTE WHAT THEY HAVE SAID, WITH ROUGH DATES IF YOU HAVE THEM]
>
> Sort it into three lists: THINGS THEY SAID DIRECTLY, in their own words; THINGS THEY HAVE SHOWN BY WHAT THEY DO, from routines or choices I described; and THINGS THE FAMILY BELIEVES THEY WANT BUT THEY HAVE NOT SAID. Put nothing in the first list that isn't a quote. Then write four everyday questions I could ask them to fill in what's missing, about a good day, a bad day, and what they'd hate to lose.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

How short the first list is compared to the third. That gap is the work.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask them two of the four questions, and write down the answers as they said them.

PROMPT 2

Give every relative the same three questions

WHY THIS MATTERS

Disagreement is easier to see when everyone answers the same questions in the same shape. It also stops one person's long argument from counting more than another's short one.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

Each involved relative's answer to: What are you most worried about? What outcome do you hope for? What can you realistically do yourself?

COPY THIS PROMPT

> I asked each family member involved in this decision three questions: what are you most worried about, what outcome do you hope for, and what can you realistically do yourself. Here are their answers:
>
> [PASTE EACH PERSON'S ANSWERS, LABELED BY NAME OR INITIAL]
>
> First, make a table with one row per person and the three questions as columns, giving each person the same amount of space whether they wrote two lines or two pages. Then write two lists: WHERE WE AGREE and WHERE WE DISAGREE, in neutral wording. Last, note where someone's hoped-for outcome depends on more caregiving than they said they could give. Don't say who is right.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

Agreement you didn't know was there, and a hope that doesn't match the hours someone can give.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Send the table to everyone who answered and ask if their row is fair.

PROMPT 3

Name the decision and what it depends on

WHY THIS MATTERS

'What should we do about Dad' is not a decision. 'Does she go home from rehab on the 14th or somewhere else first' is. A named decision shows you what facts it rests on, and which of those facts you don't have.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

The decision as you understand it, any dates attached, and what you know and assume about the situation.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is the care decision my family has to make, with the date if there is one, and what we know and assume about the situation behind it:
>
> [PASTE THE DECISION, DATES, AND YOUR NOTES]
>
> Restate the decision in one plain sentence. Then give me three lists: WHAT WE KNOW FOR CERTAIN, WHAT WE ARE ASSUMING, and QUESTIONS WE MUST ANSWER BEFORE WE DECIDE. Beside each question, mark who can answer it: the person themselves, the family, a doctor or nurse, a care consultant, or not sure. Do not recommend an option, do not compare places or services, and do not say whether the current situation is safe.

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A decision stated in one sentence everyone would accept, and the questions only the person themselves can answer.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Ask the person the questions marked as theirs, before anyone else's get answered.

PROMPT 4

Write the sheet for the family meeting

WHY THIS MATTERS

A meeting with a sheet in front of it stays on the subject. A meeting without one is decided by whoever is most tired of talking. The sheet keeps the person's words at the top of the page and the disagreements in plain view.

WHAT YOU'LL NEED

All three results from the prompts above.

COPY THIS PROMPT

> Here is everything I've gathered ahead of our family's decision about the person I'm caring for:
>
> [PASTE ALL THREE RESULTS FROM THE PROMPTS ABOVE]
>
> Write a one-page sheet with four headings: WHAT THEY HAVE TOLD US THEY WANT, using only their own words; WHERE WE AGREE; WHERE WE DON'T, stated so that no relative would feel misrepresented; and QUESTIONS TO ANSWER BEFORE WE DECIDE, each tagged with who answers it. Give the first heading the most space. Do not add a recommendation, a list of options, or any criteria for choosing between them. Leave a blank line at the end headed “What we agreed to find out next.”

WHAT TO LOOK FOR

A page where the person's voice comes first and nobody's view has been quietly dropped.

WHAT TO DO NEXT

Read the first section aloud to start the family meeting. Then bring the sheet to the next step below.

Bring their wishes into the full picture.

You've written down what the person wants and where the family stands. The care interview puts that next to a complete account of their situation, in one Family Care Profile, so the decision can rest on the whole picture instead of the loudest part of it.

Create Your Free Family Care Profile ›